In Your Hat

By Ellen Conford

INTRODUCTION

High school is tough enough without being emotionally ambushed by a girl in a pink sweater wielding fake French literature. This is a tale of love, lies, and literary hoaxes in which Dennis, a chronic underachiever and wannabe Romeo, finally gets noticed by the elusive Ariel Greenbanks. Armed with nothing but panic, a dubious history of practical jokes, and a suspicious enthusiasm for hat-based tragedies, Dennis learns the hard way that you should never trust a girl who throws out 'tuberculosis' and 'relevant' in the same conversation. Madame de Maupassant by Emile Bovary may be fake news, but Dennis's humiliation is very, very real.

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DENNIS: **(Pg 11- 21)** I was in the non-silent study area of the library on the last Sunday of midwinter break when Ariel Greenbanks noticed me. *(Ariel enters and tosses her hair)* I'd been trying to get Ariel to notice me for almost 2 years now, and the results had been grim to none. So, when she paused next to my chair, I seized the opportunity. *(to Ariel)* Hey, good lookin'. Come here often?

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ARIEL: *(picking up a couple of books from the table)* As a matter of fact, yes. *(looking at titles)* Joseph Conrad? Jane Austen?

DENNIS: Well, uh . . . *(to audience)* I hesitated. She was seeing a side of me she'd never seen before, which wasn't surprising, since I don't have that side. She liked the Mensa type. But you can't base a relationship on lies. I couldn't pretend I was an intellectual giant. *(to Ariel)* Actually, I'm in kind of a crisis here. An emergency book report.

ARIEL: Oh. When is it due?

DENNIS: *(sighing heavily)* Tomorrow.

ARIEL: Tomorrow. That ***is*** an emergency. Well, which one of these did you read?

DENNIS: I haven't exactly gotten to the reading stage yet. *(to audience)* I didn't want to tell her that I had only gotten to the "which is the shortest book you can find?" stage. *(shocked and elated)* [But] Ariel Greenbanks, wearing a cute pink sweater, was talking to me! She slid into the chair next to mine and scooped some of the books toward her. She wanted to help me!

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ARIEL: All of these are pretty short.

DENNIS: Short was the first requirement – and big print! *(disapproving look from Ariel)* I mean, because of the crisis. . . It's not like I don't ***like*** to read.

ARIEL: Maybe you could write about something you've already read. What was the last book you liked?

DENNIS: The Sponge People of Cyberia – [but] Mr. Frazetti has this prejudice against science fiction . . .

ARIEL: Have you read anything that isn't science fiction?

DENNIS: The Microbe Hunters. But I can't use that one. *(to audience)* After 4 years of handing in the same book report I'd written in 7th grade, the book report cops had finally caught up with me. Frankly, I don't think teachers ought to trade information about their students. Isn't that like a breach of doctor-patient confidentiality? (to Ariel, desperately) What am I going to do?

ARIEL: *(smiling sympathetically)* You'd better come to my house.

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DENNIS: Her house! Alone with Ariel. With ***her***! She and I. Her and me? Whatever.

*****Scene change******

ARIEL: *(scanning her bookcase)* Darn it. I can't find it. It was perfect. Short, but a minor classic. Mr. Frazetti would have been impressed. It was so great! About the millinery industry in France and this poor little woman who had all her hat designs stolen by an evil corporation. So vivid, so alive! I mean you could feel the hunger and the cold gnawing at you. *(deep inhale)* You could smell the slop in the Paris streets.

DENNIS: *(inhales, with a cough, matching her excitement)* I know what you mean!

ARIEL: And it's so relevant. Even now. You could compare it to how today's giant corporations swallow ups the little guy. *C'est la vie.*

DENNIS: *(parroting) La vie (to audiene)* A brief scowl flash[ed] across her brow. I hoped she hadn't suddenly remembered the 26 pizzas I'd had delivered to her.

ARIEL: I really shouldn't do this . . .

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DENNIS: *(eagerly)* What shouldn't you do? And will you do it??

ARIEL: I could tell you about the book . . .

DENNIS: *(to audience)* Had she finally realized we were destined to be together. Had she seen beyond the jokes and discovered the tormented soul beneath? The Me who could only express his love behind a mask of comedy?

ARIEL: *(flirtatiously)* Can you stay awhile? This will take some time . . .

DENNIS: *(to audience)* I went home with 5 pages of notes and headed for my computer. It wasn't easy to concentrate with visions of Ariel dancing in my head. Her soft, pink sweater . . . [No!] I was supposed to be thinking of French hats and imagining the crude, clashing noises of the Parisian slums. It really ***was*** a good story. This poor French girl marries a real loser who gets drunk a lot and beats her, and finally dies when he gets run over by a thresher in the potato fields where he's been trying to eke out a living by growing (of course) potatoes!

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ARIEL: *(takes over the story telling)* She goes to Paris to support herself by making hats. It turns out she's really talented!

DENNIS: Things are looking up for Madam de Maupassant.

ARIEL: Until she meets this high-class society guy. (named Guy, as a matter of fact) Only, he's down on his luck too and really needs money to pay of his gambling debts.

DENNIS: But Madam de Maupassant doesn't know any of that! She falls madly in love with him and he asks her to marry him.

ARIEL: But . . . on the day they're supposed to be married. He disappears, taking all her original hat designs with him.

DENNIS: He sells her designs to *(checks his notes)* Le Chic Chapeau, a big hat company and runs off to Algeria and is never heard from again.

ARIEL: *(dramatically)* Madame de Maupassant is heartbroken, gets tuberculosis, and wastes away – a pitiful shadow of her former self.

DENNIS: She doesn't even have money for a bowl of

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soup, let alone medicine. Finally, just as she takes her dying breath, there's a knock at the door. One of her old customers wants her to design all the hats for her daughter's wedding.

ARIEL: *(dramatically)* But it's too late. [She] can barely whisper . . "Entrez" when she gasps *(gasps)* and dies.

DENNIS: I'm telling you it was a terrific story! I was sniffling a little as I wrote out the plot. *(proudly)* AND I made a comparison between Madame de Maupassant and the economics of today. How the book was still relevant even though it was written 120 years ago. I printed out my report and was asleep before midnight . . . to dream of Ariel, in pink, trying on hats. Big flowery, poufy, old-fashioned hats!

ARIEL: *(with a French accent)* But of course I care what you think, Dennis. I want to look pretty for you.

DENNIS: On Monday I handed in my book report and spent the next two days trying to thank Ariel. I wanted to buy her lunch on Tuesday.

ARIEL: *(disdainfully, motioning to her tray)* I have lunch already.

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DENNIS: On Wednesday I asked if she'd go to the library with me. I had an urge to read Madame de Maupassant. Ariel had made it sound so good. Plus, in case Mr. Frazetti asked me any questions about it I'd be ready for him.

ARIEL: *(shaking her head)* Band practice . . . *(flounces off)*

DENNIS: On Thursday Mr. Frazetti handed our book reports back. I sat straight and proud at my desk, waiting for my A, picturing the kiss Ariel would give me when I showed her my report. *(puckers up at the thought)* Usually I was in no hurry to get my assignments back. But today was different!

MR. FRAZETTI: *(thrusting the report toward Dennis)* ***Really***, Mr. Murphy.

DENNIS: *(looking down at his paper)* Madam de Maupassant by Emile Bovary . . . F!! Underneath he'd written . . .

MR. FRAZETTI: *(indignant)* F as in FAKE!! Do you think I'm an idiot??

DENNIS: I couldn't have been more stunned if I'd been

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captured by the Sponge People of Cyberia. How could he possibly know that I hadn't really read the book? How could he know that Ariel had told me the story? Did she get the plot wrong? *(leafing through the paper to the last page)* At the bottom Mr. Frazetti had written . . .

MR. FRAZETTI: There will be no Makeup for this assignment. You have made up enough already!

DENNIS: *(covering his eyes, dramatically)* Despair and confusion overwhelmed me. Just as Le Chic Chapeau had overwhelmed Madame de Maupassant. *(dramatic pause)* I cornered Ariel near the parking lot exit. She was with two other girls who started giggling the moment they saw me. *(to Ariel, pulling out his report)* Look at this! ***Look*** at this!

ARIEL: *(innocently)* Oh, my. An F. That's not good.

DENNIS: *(livid)* Not good? It's terrible! Why did I get an F?

ARIEL: Well, maybe because I made it up.

DENNIS: Made it up? Made what up? What are you ***talking*** about?!

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ARIEL: *(with a sweet devious smile)* The thing is, there really is no such book as Madame de Maupassant. I made it up. The whole story.

DENNIS: *(stammering)* No such book? But – but – *(wailing)* but why????

ARIEL: *(laughing)* It was a joke, Dennis. Just a little joke. *(turns to leave)*

DENNIS: It's not funny! Ariel!!!!

ARIEL: *(turns and tilts her head)* You don't think so?

DENNIS: *(shouting)* No! You really got me in trouble!

ARIEL: *(hands on her hips, shaking her head)* For heaven's sake, Dennis. *(with a French accent)* What's happened to your sense of humor? *(exits)*

DENNIS: *(yelling to Ariel's back)* My ***great*** sense of humor ***AND*** my legendary reputation for practical jokes! You can't base a relationship on lies!

ARIEL: *C'est la vie!*

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AWARD HISTORY

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